

The Big Three (but in gaming)

It seems odd to say it, but Microsoft is once again part of the big three in gaming. Why does it feel odd you ask? Well because the impression was that Microsoft always was part of the big three in gaming, alongside Sony and Nintendo. That could also just be my age showing. As it turns out, while Sony is certainly in the top three, Nintendo isn't. And neither of the three are actually number one, it's a wee company called Tencent, which I'm sure you've all heard of. Well, with the number of pies Tencent has its fingers dipped in, it only makes sense if you think about it.

Anyway, the reason I'm bringing this up is because Microsoft just announced their plans to purchase Activision Blizzard for a whopping \$69 billion, making it the biggest tech purchase of all time. Not two console generations ago, if you asked me who was winning the console wars, I would have said Sony hands down. The main reason being the number of (good) exclusives on the platform. Xbox just seemed lackluster, with only Halo and Forza barely keeping it afloat. However, if you ask me the same question now, it becomes much harder to answer. While Sony still has all its exclusives in tow, they've started to forgo exclusivity for older titles, and opt for limited exclusivity for future titles. This is great news for PC gamers like me, but I definitely think it also has to do with the wild success Xbox Play Anywhere and the Xbox Games Pass is seeing.

The Xbox Game Pass is incredible value for money if you own an Xbox or have a PC. The biggest issue with gaming on a console, in addition to the high initial costs of purchasing the console itself, was the cost of games. The Xbox Game Pass solves this problem. With a small monthly fee, you have access to a massive library of games, with new titles coming to Game Pass on day one, even from massive AAA publishers, including those that Microsoft hasn't gobbled up yet. Each new acquisition makes Game Pass stronger. Even other companies have seen value in this, EA, and more recently, Ubisoft, both have their own sub-



scriptions bundled up with the Game Pass. I think the only reason Sony finally decided to drop exclusivity was because they saw the threat that Microsoft and Xbox were finally posing. It was naturally a smart move; opening up your games to more platforms means more profit. God of War 2018 which just came out on PC was the most played game on Steam on the day of its launch, and we're crossing our fingers for Forbidden West making its way to PC soon.

Competition is always good for the consumer, which is ultimately what led to all this. Us gamers benefit from it the most. But I've got another question for you, what are your thoughts on Microsoft gobbling studios up? Are we heading towards a gaming monopoly? Let me know. *

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